‘Doing’ DH in the Indian Vernacular/s: Ensuring Access and Accessibility Through Vernacular Medium Instruction (?)

Ghosh, Sharanya
ghosh.5@iitj.ac.in
Indian Institute of Technology Jodhpur

Rathod, Arpita
arpitarathod98@gmail.com
Ravenshaw University

The interrogation mark in the title indicates some of the questions we raise (and delve into) through this presentation, which focuses on the Indian Government’s recent push towards introducing vernacular medium instruction at the higher education level. English has been the lingua franca of instruction at the higher education level in India since the colonial era. This often comes as a sudden break for many students who have earlier studied in vernacular medium schools. While some regional universities allow using vernacular languages at the undergraduate and postgraduate levels for specific subjects, the overall gap between school and higher education systems stays unbridgeable. To mitigate this problem and ensure a more enthusiastic use of vernacular languages in ‘every’ aspect of life, the Government of India has been pushing for launching individual courses and programmes taught in Indian vernacular/s. Although tech education is the primary target in this endeavour, bodies such as the University Grants Commission (UGC) have also released policy documents encouraging the same for non-technical education. The Ministry of Education, UGC and similar bodies also offer financial benefits for instructors/educators/scholars who might contribute towards this endeavour by writing original textbooks, translating existing works, or developing course materials in Indian vernacular language/s. Institutions such as the Indian Institute of Technology Jodhpur already initiated a Hindi-language BTech programme in its 2024 academic year for students who are not proficient enough in English.

It is not ironic that this nationalistic fervour in the name of promoting a more widespread use of Indian vernacular/s can be viewed as a response to India’s long colonial past. English was and still is one of the two official languages besides Hindi and twenty-two scheduled languages, as recognized by the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution of India. As much as this new initiative is commendable, its feasibility remains a serious concern, especially for academic domains like the Digital Humanities, where global scholarship majorly revolves around anglophone culture. There has been much conversation over multilingual DH celebrating and embracing multiple linguistic identities (Russell, 2014; Fiormonte, 2021; Horvath, 2021). With its colonial past, India has been at the forefront of this revolution. Despite such efforts, ADHO’s CFP is still only available in its six official languages, underlining the exclusivity of European languages. However, we do not critique tendencies in global DH discourses. We investigate the possibilities of a Digital Humanities space in the Indian academia accessible to its vernacular users, which is indeed possible (at least in theory) through the initiatives mentioned above. We explore both the avenues of translated and original writings in Indian vernacular/s in promoting DH scholarship in India. As an interdisciplinary field, DH requires a robust academic framework and resources to suit the multifaceted demands of the domain. However, to our knowledge, currently available textbooks/academic resources in DH are primarily in English or non-Indian languages. Considering, on the one hand, the buzz around vernacular medium instruction and, on the other, the hype around interdisciplinary pursuits such as DH, we explore the following questions through our presentation-

- Who are the facilitators of vernacular medium instruction in the Digital Humanities in India?
- What kind of access is facilitated through this shift (e.g., ease of accessing the job market)?
- How is the quality of education maintained in this shift?
  - Who ensures this quality?

To arrive at a holistic understanding of the issues, we will focus on the possibilities of using translation and making original works in vernacular/s in DH teaching and practice in India.

Existing studies

Vernacularization of education gained prominence in India with the National Education Policy 2020 launch, which focuses on using regional languages in teaching-learning. This created a space for regional languages to be used as a medium of teaching in schools and higher education institutions. The aim is to promote the use of vernacular/s

while at the same time producing knowledge systems and resources in the language. Many institutions have risen to the challenge of offering technical BTech. courses in vernacular language. This review situates the problems associated with vernacular instruction/education for DH by examining recent reports on vernacular-medium tech education in India vis-à-vis DH scholarship on linguistic inclusion. A report from 2024 applauds IIT Jodhpur's decision to teach BTech. courses in Hindi notes that this will help foster a more inclusive environment for students to learn, where they do not have to put in extra effort to overcome the language barrier. Nevertheless, this raises the question of how students would access resources (textbooks and journals) related to their subjects, as they are primarily produced in English. A similar problem also exists in DH, where teaching and learning happens in English despite the possibility of offering vernacular resources. Quinn Dombrowski (2023) summarises the challenges and problems of using languages other than English by rightly pointing out that the DH scholarship is primarily in English. Even the NLP tools used in text analysis cater to the English language. She further notes that the default of English is so prevalent that professors and educators must often be made aware of it. So, this raises an important question: How does one teach and practice multilingual DH if there is no space for it in scholarship?

People associated with vocational education believe that multilingual teaching helps them to connect with their students as most of their students are from rural areas. As noted by Gayathri Vasudevan (2022), Chief Impact Officer at Sambhav Foundation, a multilingual environment boosts the students' confidence by creating an inclusive space for students from vernacular-medium to interact with teacher/instructor. As we examine the possibility of doing DH in Indian vernacular/s to ensure inclusivity and accessibility, we need to foreground the need for DH facilitators to first contextualize their teaching-learning practices in the Indian context. Risam's (2016) idea of a 'DH accent' to situate DHers in their local contexts, making 'doing DH' more accessible to its users, may be helpful. Identifying one's DH accent helps locate their positionality and the differences in the global contexts. To utilize language as a vehicle of inclusivity/accessibility, facilitators must first identify the linguistic and otherwise context. Furthermore, we also seek to answer the possibility of training facilitators in one or more vernaculars to warrant a wholesome teaching-learning experience.

A final issue is the feasibility question. A student publication from IIT Bombay (2021) raises an important question: while vernacular education may benefit students in learning, English remains the language of communication for job interviews and career growth in general. DH is not new to Indian/South Asian scholarship, as contended by Roy and Menon (2022). However, DH's interdisciplinary status puts it in a precarious condition. Ghosh et al. (2023) reported on the prevalent tech-positivism within the Indian DH community, leading to flagship DH programmes in premier Indian tech institutions. In that sense, the government's push towards vernacular-medium tech education, thus, should also promote vernacular-medium DH instruction and knowledge production. The ground truth, however, is quite different. Neither are we aware of any such course/programme in DH being offered nor are we familiar with any academic resources, digital or analogue, that students may use, available in any Indian language. Even if we celebrate the government's incentivizing efforts, let us not forget the complexities of translation and the limitations of machine translation in Indian languages, besides the question of how much to translate, i.e., whether facilitators should aim for complete translation or restrict themselves to mixing existing DH terminology with vernacular resources to avoid obfuscation.

Methodology and Intended Audience

We employ a mixed methods approach involving case study analysis and survey methods to explore our research questions. We analyse the DH MSc. programme offered by IIT Jodhpur for the past 4 years to dig into its demographic structuring, curricular requirements, curriculum, and the likelihood of a vernacular-medium instruction. IITJ's status as one of the pioneers in Hindi-medium instruction at the BTech. level makes its MSc. in DH programme the best choice. For our survey, we utilize resources such as the Hindi Wikipedia page on DH to gather students' responses on comprehensibility, reliability of information, accessibility, etc. At this stage of our study, we can only canvass Hindi-speaking respondents owing to feasibility and resource shortage. By employing mixed methods, we can uphold the interdisciplinary principles of DH that aim to balance the quantitative and qualitative, positivist and interpretivist, objective and subjective.

Despite our study's specific geographical location, we trust our commentary will interest all such multilingual DHers who struggle to discourse on DH in both academic and non-academic settings involving speakers of non-European languages. Our findings will prove particularly beneficial to facilitators who aim to introduce DH to their vernacular-speaking learners- to tailor their course contents to the heterogeneity of a

DH classroom while adjusting to the limitations of resource availability or knowledge production in languages other than the normative.

Bibliography

Agarwal, Ayush/ Poddar , Ishita. (2021): "B.Tech in Vernacular Languages", in: *Insight IIT Bombay* https://insightiitb.org/b-tech-in-vernacular-languages/ . [15.10.2024].

Bahrawi, Nazry. (2020): "A vocabulary of our own", in: *Academia | SG* https://www.academia.sg/academic-views/a-vocabulary-of-our-own/ [9.4.2024].

Cro, Melinda A. (2020). *Integrating the digital humanities into the second language classroom : a practical guide* . Georgetown University Press.

Fiormonte, Domenico. (2021). "Taxation against Overrepresentation? The Consequences of Monolingualism for Digital Humanities.", in: Kim, Dorothy/ Koh, Adeline (Eds.): *Alternative Historiographies of the Digital Humanities* . Punctum Books 333–375. https://muse.jhu.edu/pub/319/oa_edited_volume/chapter/2941213 . [21.10.2024].

Galina Russell, Isabel . (2014). "Geographical and linguistic diversity in the Digital Humanities", in: *Literary and Linguistic Computing 29* , 3: 307–316. https://doi.org/10.1093/llc/fqu005 . [15.10.2024].

Ghosh, Sharanya/ Dahiya, Vasundhra, Dahiya, Lavanya/ Chadha, Aanya. (2023). "D or H – What leads in DH? Envisaging the Digital Humanities Space in India". https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.8260322 . [4.2.2024].

"Guidelines for translation of books into Indian Languages". (n.d.). https://www.ugc.gov.in/pdfnews/5634541_Translation-to-indian-languages-Guidelines.pdf . [7.12.2024].

Horvath, Aliz. (2021). "Enhancing Language Inclusivity in Digital Humanities: Towards Sensitivity and Multilingualism", in: *Modern Languages Open 1* . https://doi.org/10.3828/mlo.v0i0.382 . [5.11.2024].

"IIT Madras NPTEL translates technical courses into multiple vernacular languages". (2024), in: *Hindustan Times* . https://www.hindustantimes.com/education/features/iit-madras-nptel-translates-technical-courses-into-multiple-vernacular-languages-101712741992834.html . [5.11.2024].

"IIT Jodhpur breaks language barrier, launches BTech courses in Hindi". (2024) https://www.moneycontrol.com/education/iit-jodhpur-breaks-language-barrier-launches-btech-courses-in-hindi-article-12766973.html . [4.10.2024]

Murray, Padmini R./ Hand, Chirs. (2015). "Making Culture: Locating the Digital Humanities in India:, in: *Visible Language* 49, 3. https://journals.uc.edu/index.php/vl/article/view/5910 . [3.10.2024].

"myScheme - One-stop search and discovery platform of the Government schemes". (2024). https://www.myscheme.gov.in . [7.12.2024].

Prakash, Arun. (2024a). "A language shift in the future of coding", in: *Deccan Herald* . https://www.deccanherald.com//education/a-language-shift-in-the-future-of-coding-3097533 . [10.7.2024]

Quinn, Dombrowski. (2023). "Bringing Languages into the DH Classroom", in: Croxall, Brian/ Jakacki, Diane, K. (Eds.): *What We Teach When We Teach DH* . University of Minnesota Press.

Ramanathan, Vaidehi. (2006). "The Vernacularization of English: Crossing Global Currents to Re-dress West-based TESOL", in: *Critical Inquiry in Language Studies 3* , 2-3: 131–146. https://doi.org/10.1080/15427587.2006.9650843 . [1.9.2024].

Ravichandran, P./ Abraham, Prakash. (2022). "Vernacular Language in Higher Education: An Analysis from LIS Perspective", in: *RRRLF Sponsored SALIS 2022: National Conference on Transformation of Learning Resource Centers in the Digital Era* , Tamilnadu, October, 2022. https://www.researchgate.net/publication/369185572_Vernacular_Language_in_Higher_Education_An_Analysis_from_LIS_Perspective . [1.9.2024].

Risam, Rupika. (2016). "Other Worlds, Other DHs: Notes towards a DH Accent", in: *Digital Scholarship in the Humanities* 32, 2. https://doi.org/10.1093/llc/fqv063 . [7.11.2023].

Roy, Dibyadyuti/ Menon, Nirmala . (2022). "No "Making," Not Now: Decolonizing Digital Humanities in South Asia", in: Ricaurte, Paola / Chaudhuri, Sukanta/ Fiormonte, Dominico (Eds.): *Global Debates in the Digital Humanities* , 186–201. University of Minnesota Press. https://muse.jhu.edu/pub/23/oa_edited_volume/chapter/3144064/pdf . [7.12.2024].

Saxena, Akshya. (2022). *Vernacular English: Reading the Anglophone in Postcolonial India* . Princeton University Press.

Soria, Ignacio A./ Issel-Dombert, Sandra/ García, Laura M. (2023). *Language, Migration and Multilingualism in the Age of Digital Humanities* . De Gruyter.

"Technical education in mother tongue to end urban-rural gap: President Droupadi Murmu". (2022), in: *The Times of India.* https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/city/bhubaneswar/technical-education-in-mother-tongue-to-end-urban-rural-gap-

president-droupadi-murmu/
articleshow/95466356.cms . [17.8.2024].

Vaidehi Ramanathan. (2007). *The English-vernacular divide postcolonial language politics and practice* . Hyderabad Orient Longman.

Vasudevan, Gayathri. (2024). “Pushing vocational education towards vernacular learning”. https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/pushing-vocational-education-towards-
vernacular-gayathri-vasudevan . [7.11.2024].

Viola, Lorella/ Spence, Paul. (2023). *Multilingual Digital Humanities* . Taylor & Francis.

Wikipedia Contributors . (2024). “Non-English-based programming languages”, in: *Wikipedia* . https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?title=Non-English-based_programming_language-
s&oldid=1260784818 . [17.8.2024].